good governance, and democracy, it might fall to communism – abetted by Moscow through the Communist Party of India. Finally, in the US view, China did not have the attractions of the USSR or its resources, but its economic success might swing the developing countries, including India, towards socialism and the communist bloc.

It was against this possibility that by the mid-1950s President Dwight Eisenhower and Senator (later President) John F. Kennedy came to see India as pivotal in the fight against communism despite its irksome non-alignment. Eisenhower, unlike his predecessor Harry Truman, hit it off with Nehru, and paid a successful visit to India in 1959 just as relations between Delhi and Beijing were becoming acrimonious and violent. Nehru, setting aside his snobbishness over American materialism and brashness, had been to Washington three years earlier. He had been received warmly by Eisenhower in 1956 – an American news clip shows Nehru bounding up the White House steps to meet the US President, and the two leaders seemed to genuinely enjoy each other's company. The newsreel shows a rather happily grinning Vice President Richard Nixon on the steps of the White House – the same Nixon who would be so anti-India later (and so racist). In the same year, Kennedy famously articulated a growing view that there was a competition between India and China and that Washington should weigh in: 'No struggle in the world today deserves more of our time and attention than that which now grips the attention of all Asia . . . And that is the struggle between India and China for leadership of the East . . . We want India to win that race.'[1]

Delhi's relations with Moscow had been frosty in the initial years, but in 1953, with the death of Stalin, the Indian ambassador Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan started to get time with the Soviet leadership. Stalin's successor, Khrushchev, quickly toned down the hostility to Nehru, India's democracy, and non-alignment. Nehru visited Moscow in July 1955, and Khrushchev returned the visit in November of the same year. During his visit, Khrushchev supported India's view on the liberation of Goa from Portuguese rule and Kashmir's future status. Soviet aid to India followed, including the setting up of the Bhilai steel plant, the first time Moscow had